Serve this delightful soup with some nutty rye bread and chilled unsalted butter. If you like, you can use crab for a less expensive alternative to the lobster.

brandied lobster chowder

SERVES 4 **PREP** 20 MINS **COOK** 1 HR **FREEZE** UP TO 2 MONTHS WITHOUT HALF-AND-HALF AND SNOW PEAS

1 small cooked lobster
3½ cups water
⅔ cup dry white wine
1 bay leaf
1–2 tbsp unsalted butter
2 shallots, finely chopped
4 tbsp brandy
1 large tomato, peeled and diced
2 tsp anchovy essence
4 large new potatoes, peeled and diced
8 baby corn, cut in short lengths
salt and freshly ground pepper
2oz (60g) snow peas, cut in short lengths
5 tbsp half-and-half
4 thick slices lemon
4 sprigs of parsley

1 Twist the legs and claws off the lobster. Split the body lengthwise and remove the vein that runs along it. Remove the tail meat, cut in small pieces, and reserve. Crack the large claws, remove the meat, dice, and reserve. Keep all other meat in the shell. Coarsely chop it and put it in a saucepan with the claws and legs. Add the water, wine, and bay leaf. Bring to a boil, reduce the heat, cover, and simmer for 30 minutes. Strain and reserve the stock.

2 Melt the butter in another large saucepan over low heat. Add the shallots and cook gently, stirring for 1 minute. Add the brandy, ignite, and shake the pan until the flames subside. Add the tomato, anchovy essence, potatoes, and corn. Return the stock to the pan. Season and bring to a boil. Reduce the heat, cover, and simmer gently for 20 minutes until the potatoes are really tender.

3 Meanwhile, blanch the snow peas in a little boiling water for 2 minutes until just tender. Drain, rinse with cold water, and drain again. Then add to the soup along with the half-and-half and lobster meat. Taste and season again. Reheat the soup but do not boil it. Ladle into deep soup cups. Serve with a slice of lemon and a small sprig of parsley in each bowl.